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Joey Morant

Trumpeter and vocalist Joey Morant is a dynamic performer who evokes the spirit of Louis Armstrong and Red Allen. He has shared the stage with Ray Charles, Lionel Hampton and Count Basie, and his consummate skills as an entertainer have found a welcome home with the Harlem Blues and Jazz Band.

Joey was interviewed in Clinton, New York on April 2, 2013 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive. Joey's wife Linda participated briefly in the interview.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. And I'm happy to have Joey Morant with me today. And I'm not sure how to describe you. Because musician doesn't do all of it. But you are an entertainer.

JM: A kick boxer.

MR: A kick boxer, and a bringer of spirit.

JM: Hello. Amen.

MR: I also know you're well traveled because of your hat from Japan.

JM: From Russia. I just got back from Russia.

MR: From Russia. Okay.

JM: I'm a black Russian. I love it. That's what they call me.

MR: Well welcome to Hamilton. You know I had this thought this morning when you were playing in class — I never got to hear Roy Eldridge live. But from the description, I thought of you.

JM: Thank you.

MR: The way you play.

JM: Thank you, sir. It's an honor to hear that. Because I've heard that before from Billy Eckstine's son, Ed Eckstine, who is still alive and well in a rep company. Roy Eldridge. I knew his daughter very well too, Carol, before she died.

MR: Well what is it — can you tell me what you think about when you play a solo?

JM: When I improvise?

MR: Yeah.

JM: Jazz. Because I improvise R&B and gospel. When I improvise jazz I'm thinking how fortunate it would be if the young people, especially the minority — I want to underscore that because they came up from the bottom line — the blacks, the Hispanics, some Jews — if only it would reflect on their structure, life structure, in music, when they start to improvise. Tell a story emphatically about what makes them unique as a person in spite of the conditions, not because of the conditions. So I think of me as being a little boy who

sold watermelon back on the truck in Charleston, South Carolina, I sold apples and oranges. [sings] Get your apples today. And like a typical Little Black Sambo at that time. I say typical because you were expected to act black back then. I call it acting black. Get your watermelon today. Now we have some watermelon — like George Gershwin said, Get your watermelon today. And I sold Christmas trees. I was a hamburger maker, BLT, pig in a blanket which is a hot dog wrapped in cheese. So I did culinary work, I cut grass with a sling, long before I got my hand on a lawn mower, then I got a lawn mower that was non-electric — push pull, push pull. Then I finally graduated to an electric lawn mower. So I did a lot of menial work when I was little, and happily so. When I improvise I see me as being humble, a kid with humility, who never blamed anybody for anything, I don't care how black I was, I don't care how white you were, none of it mattered. The only thing that matters is the moment — the psychological stratagem of the moment, what I'm doing in that moment. Now when I was dishwashing in the Honey House Restaurant in Charleston, South Carolina, I never thought Lord why me. I never thought Lord why me. And even today, too many kids, especially black ones, are saying Lord why me. Why not you? Pick up the pieces. That guy in the white band said, "Pick up the pieces."

MR: Well when did the trumpet come along then, to replace those menial jobs?

JM: I was eleven years old, and what grade was I, maybe the fifth grade. Because I started school at seven, not six. Back then six was the starting grade for poor people. There was no kindergarten for most people. They couldn't afford it. So they started at six. But I was sickly, very sick when I was little, so I started at seven, a year behind my original class. My high school class was 1957, but it should have been '56 you see. However, God has helped me to kind of make up for some of that, and I got a leaky trumpet out of the attic in the elementary school in Charlestown, South Carolina. Henry P. Archer School. That was the name of the school. And my seventh grade teacher introduced me to the trumpet in the attic — just, you know, things that were left behind from a little black school in Charleston. And it was leaky. And you know when you've got a leak you've got to blow harder, because air escapes. So I tied it up with a handkerchief and took it home. And I really wanted to play the saxophone. Because the guy who introduced me to music played sax. My greatest love for music at that time was the saxophone. Why I didn't play it? At that time I couldn't afford the mouthpiece. A mouthpiece back then was six dollars, I had two dollars. So when I found out what was available on John Street from Bruce Music Store, a trumpet mouthpiece of brass, and started playing the trumpet.

MR: What kind of music was being played in your home?

JM: Mostly gospel, R&B, 78 records. Ruth Brown, Rasheed Young, Mahalia Jackson, the lady that recorded "Fine Brown Frame" who was that, a delegate to Union 47, Nellie

Lutcher, [sings] Fine Brown Frame/I wonder what could be his name. She also recorded a song called "My Mother's Eye" was the name of the song. A standard. And I recorded that on my latest CD. "My Mother's Eye." A tribute to mothers. Nellie Lutcher, who had a hit record in '48, who ended up being a delegate in the union, Local 47, Los Angeles. So I picked my samples from things in the air, and when I was sick in the hospital — I was in the hospital a lot — and they had the metal posts on the bed where you could ring here, and it made music. Remember that? That got me into wanting some classical music. I didn't know what classical music was. I didn't know it was called classical music. I just heard [scats]. I heard successions of beats being played in my head and intermittently I would hear some music like that. I didn't know what it was called. So I came up dirt poor. Dirt poor meaning as poor as you can possibly get and as black as you can possibly get. Jet black. So all of the disadvantages were there, except my mother — God rest her soul — taught me how to love, spread charity, the church, at that time Jesus Christ. So I grew up in the church, Sunday school, they called it Sunday school. We learned about the Bible. Sunday school. And right after Sunday school was the regular church service which starts at eleven o'clock. After church service we may have prayer meeting for the real church-goers. Then there was night service. So I was in church all day Sunday. So that kind of taught me about music also.

MR: And what kind of music did they have in your church?

JM: They had Negro spirituals. It was called Negro spirituals. "Precious Lord Take My Hand," "Old Rugged Cross," "Softly and Tender Jesus is Calling Me" — you know, the things in the hymn book. Mostly hymn book songs. But at night we would have Negro spirituals, which has its roots in slavery, from hummin'.

MR: Did people sing in harmony?

JM: Well, other than Gregorian chant, which I learned to like, the harmony came out of the fields. Black folks.

MR: Um hum. But in church when they sang the hymns, did people find harmonies?

JM: Yeah. They find their intervals. Like "Precious Lord" I don't know how they did it. [sings] Take my hand/lead me on. That's the sixth. [sings] Let me stand/I am tired/I am weak — the sixth — I want — five chord — dad a eee — major seventh — de de — minor fourth — de de dee/de de da. I don't know how they knew — Take my hand was one, precious Lord — five, lead me on. How they heard that I don't know. It's got to be intrinsic. It's got to be like osmosis. In the blood. Nobody taught blacks how to harmonize. But in Africa nobody taught them either. You ever listen to Africans sing? Ethiopians? They automatically sing the right intervals from one note to the other. How is that possible?

MR: I don't know.

JM: Did they create harmony? You know, it's like, well I find in me, I find I can do things most musicians in the world can't do. Even some of the people you know. Like no lesson, no formal training, nobody, how to harmonize with any song in any mode in any key. From Tonic, Phrygian, Mixolydian, Lydian.

MR: I'm going to jump a few years here, but I wanted to know why you chose to join the Marines.

JM: A challenge. Just strictly a challenge. Same thing in the Army. It's a challenge. I always wanted to be — now this is weird — I always wanted to be a hero. Hero to me meant somebody who was way above everybody else, for whatever reason. When I was a little boy I wanted to be a fireman. I thought they were heroes, because what they had to do, better than you, to get the job done. So the guy who was upstanding was the hero. That's my definition of a hero. Everybody else was just people. The outstanding ones were heroes. That was my definition. So from that I wanted to be outstanding. That's why I loved the military. That's why I studied the martial arts. Because I wanted to be special. Not looking down on anybody else. I wanted to be better than the next guy. You know I ran six miles a day, six days a week, and kick box all week.

MR: But in the military, isn't part of their goal to make you less of an individual and more part of the group?

JM: Less of an individual in terms of your ego. But your ego gets mellowed out to stand out among the crowd. They reward people who are better than the other. But not at the expense of the other, like musicians sometimes do. They want to be stars at my expense. And why should I allow that? Because I feel I'm just — happens all the time — it's standard procedure in show business. "Wait a minute, I'd like to answer." Well maybe the answer was already said. Maybe not clear enough? Maybe louder? Or how you said it. So let him have it. Don't erase his image, his phrase. He just said it. So you don't need to say nothing. That's what you learn to do as commercial artists. I've learned it from the martial arts, this and that. That's why you notice today I didn't do a lot of talking. You don't need to. The band director has it. I don't need to prove to you I'm a general. You'll sense it. You'll feel it. You'll find out. I could talk all day if I wanted to and there never is why. Half the suggestions that were made was already made by the guy conducting the band. So I don't need to prove to him that I know. There's a mellow way to participate with students and grown-ups alike without taking charge. Because it ain't your show. You follow me? See you have to pick your spots. Like every time the director says something they would say, "And let me add to that." You don't need to add to that. That bothers me a lot.

MR: Yes.

JM: That bothers me a lot really. I'm happy knowing what I know, who I am and what I am. I don't need to prove it. You'll see it, eventually, if I can do my thing, you'll see it. I don't have to tell anybody who I am, where I went or what I do. I can write a book. That thick. More than anybody on that bandstand. I'm telling you now because you're interviewing me. You'd never know it.

MR: Was there a gig in particular, when you were young, that really set you on your path, that maybe you said wow, I can do this for a living?

JM: Um hum. The Metronome All-Stars in Charleston, South Carolina. There was a group of musicians that was led by a school teacher who played upright bass. His name was LeRoy Chisholm. I didn't know he was a principal. I didn't know anything about anything. I was just a humble kid hoping to get from one day to the next. But I found a LeRoy, a principal, a school principal. And he had the Metronome All-Stars that had a lady in the band, at the black YMCA. Everything was black and white back then by the way. Everything, even the toilets, the sink, the whatever.

MR: This was what year then?

JM: Oh 1951, '52, '53. The black YMCA on Canada Street in Charleston, South Carolina, LeRoy Chisholm performed one night. And I drifted over there because I knew the saxophone player in the band. He had a black, female trumpet player, Rae Carter from the Sweethearts of Rhythm.

MR: What's her last name?

JM: Rae Carter. C-A-R-T-E-R. From the Sweethearts of Rhythm. Remember that band? All girl band, right. And they were great. Everybody drifted into Charleston and she happened to be in Charleston. And then they'd play [trumpet interlude, "Tenderly"]. They played like that, breathing was controlled. I don't know why I paid attention to that, but I paid attention to it. I'm standing in the doorway at the YMCA [humms]. I don't know why that got my attention. Something in me wanted to be the way she was, sitting in that chair up on stage, while I stood in the doorway. When I went to high school the next day, the saxophone player, who was teaching music, who was in twelfth grade at the time, he was four years ahead of me said, "Man, you sound like Rae." So I went to the band room and I copied it. The next day, while he was there, Melvin Hodges took the band to Stone Mountain, Georgia. He took the band to the White House with Jimmy Carter. He's an expert band director, marching band and doing things on the fields. Superb educator. He said, "Man you sound like Rae." I went [scats] that's all I did. So he said, "You sound like Rae." So he introduced me to the band director and I became one of the members of the band without knowing anything. I couldn't read, I didn't know nothing. But they carried me along.

MR: Okay. You said that this morning. You said it's about songs, and it makes me think that you heard that song and it had that impression on you right back then, because it's about songs.

JM: I think we're all psychic to a degree. You are, your wife is, everybody is a psychic. They just haven't tapped it yet. You have to be a psychic to have a brain. The way the brain vibrates, the way it generates protoplasm, the way it generates juice, dendrites, you know, we're all psychic, we just haven't tapped it. When I was a little boy, because of my father, I could read people. Minds. I could read places, things. I can just about tell you when something's going to happen. Now how? How do I know that? Nobody told me. My sensors, antennas, were always way up. That's what helped me in kick boxing. I always knew what the guy was going to do in front of me. Always knew. Only a second before he knew. So music helped me do that I believe. Music, if you do it right, if you pay attention to your heart, to your mind, to your soul, if you do it right and leave the ego at the door, like Quincy Jones said, if you do it right your psychic phenomenon, your psychic thoughts, your psychic dribblings will come out of you and help you to know where normally you would not have known. You follow me? I mean to understand why we act the way we do, and to forgive. Like if I see someone that's really stupid, I try not to put them down. But maybe they don't know they're stupid. That's what they are. Like our fathers in Rome. You know, he don't know he's a rogue. So what you have to do is, if you become a really good psychic, real advanced in that kind of a mental technology, things become your responsibility to understand others. To understand that they know not why they do what they do. So your other job also is to help them get on a path so that they do understand. So your relationship with people — you're not supposed to tell them what to do, show them what to do. Don't tell them nothing. I don't want to teach you what to think, I'd like to teach you how to think.

MR: Well that's what they do here at Hamilton. That's funny you say that because that's almost like one of their slogans.

JM: Oh really?

MR: They try to teach you how to think, yes. And many of the alums will say that.

JM: Very important. Very important. I'll take a bum out of jail on death row, give me two years with him I'll change his life. I really believe I can do it. Even though he has certain impediments imbedded in him. If I can grab him and keep him two and a half years I got it. I got it.

MR: Well you have a long resume.

JM: Oh big time.

MR: Of people that you've played with. Is there someone —

JM: 55 years.

MR: Is there some one or two people you pick out from that that really maybe taught you how to think? Changed the way you thought?

JM: In Carolina, the Stumpers. You've heard of the Cotton Pickin' Stumpers, I know you have. The Carolina Cotton Pickin' Stumpers. That's a different band. I learned from the Carolina Stumpers. Frank Flood and the guys. I was 14 probably in 1953, or 13 or whatever, when these guys were already in their late twenties. And they showed me how to — what's the word I'm looking for — how to contemplate, how to regurgitate the moment, your space, your temporal space, sorting it out. And how to really be critical of yourself enough to move on. Not to go back. See when you're critical, when you're learning to be critical, now you know how to be critical. Now you know what to do with it. Because it can take you forwards and take you backwards. Because that's the highest point in reasoning. You learn to be a real critic, and critical thinking. You read a book. No two people read the same book alike. The ones the most critical, in the right manner, becomes the most progressive, takes the most steps forward. Others either stand still where they are or they go backwards. So I learned to think from the band leaders who challenged my being. One guy said to me one day, "You know that's not good and that's not right." I didn't get mad. I was happy he said that. Today somebody says, "Well what do you mean?" The attitude problem. I solved that years ago. I played a boat ride in Charleston, South Carolina with the Metronome All-Stars. I can't read nothing, I don't know nothing. The guy at the call, the guy who just died two years ago, the trumpet player in that band called Bob Buford. These are Charleston people. He had to call him in to get on the boat to play the parts that I didn't know. And he let me take the money. He didn't take the money at the end of that. And they paid for the boat ride, and he told LeRoy Chisholm to give me the money. I didn't know nothing. And so I learned to read out of the Combo Ork — O-R-K — Book. The Combo Ork Book.

MR: I know what you're talking about.

JM: Yeah. And then I learned the Latin book too. I know that's how I built my repertoire. You know, "Charmaine" "Maria Elena" — I know at least fifty-five hundred songs. Go as far back as you want. Ethnic songs too. Greek songs, Irish, Italian, Russian songs. I'm the only band that goes to Moscow that plays "Moscow Nights" at the end of the concert [scats]. And they start dancing when I play that. But the other bands don't know it. Either they didn't care to learn it, never heard it before, or it doesn't matter to them. So through all of the questions you ask me, you have to learn to care. I care about you. I look at your office and I see character. I see persona. I see a world. I see story. I see heartache. I see hurt, I see love. I see things maybe even your wife don't see. I'll challenge her. I see things. She ain't me you know. And that's why I try to show you without being overbearing. Like you made me happy just stepping in the room. Well you can't be happy

unless you feel what I feel. A lot of people come in here and look at your books. What I see is intrinsic in the air, in the mortar in the room, it's in the bricks. The room is an animal. It has a head, a body, arms, tail, legs, feet.

MR: From a practical point of view, what's it like, I mean music is an up and down business.

JM: Yup.

MR: Right?

JM: Yup. Well most of it is up and down. Music takes its toll though.

MR: What's it been like to make a living as a musician?

JM: Good for me. I never experienced a real downside. I had times when I didn't work. It didn't bother me. Because the psychology in my nature took me to another job. I made the right phone calls to the right agent at the right time, impressed him in the right manner to get the right job. Hallelujah. Another musician may be a hell of a player but can't do that. I used to call guys and pretend I was my agent. "I have this trumpet player, he's very good, he's a great guy, he happens to be black and he needs a job right now. You won't be sorry, you'll be glad you did. Give him a shot. Give him a job next tour." I did that with Harold Cutlett in Ontario, many times. I put a handkerchief over the phone back then, the black and white phone, and I'd tell them. I got me work like that. Other times I called the agent myself and I sold me. Once they see me the rest is history. That's how I learned to be an entertainer, from a guy named Shotgun Kelly. He knew how to get on stage and make any stage work, whether serious jazz, serious classical, pop, Dixieland. I guarantee you, you can't show me a hundred musicians in the next ten years who can do what I do with any stage on the planet. I don't care what the combination of attitudes, songs. I can go from James Brown to Miles Davis to Dizzy Gillespie the right way at the right time in the right place. You close your eyes you think all those people were there. Now if that ain't hard to do let somebody try it.

MR: Is it hard to find musicians —

JM: To keep up with me? Yeah. Hard. Well I suffer. That's part of my suffering. Part of it. So band leaders, kind of player-coach, I teach. They were talking about shuffle. I could have said a lot today but I don't want to. They'll look at your video. I could have said a lot today when they were talking, I chose not to say anything. I chose this you understand. Because most of the players I've met I had to kind of directly or indirectly teach them.

MR: Like you were talking about before.

JM: Even the Harlem Blues and Jazz Band. Starting in the year 2000, Al may not tell you but I'm telling you because I know, I've got proof. They would not have gotten to Europe and Sweden and Denmark without me being in the band from 2001 to now. Even now I'm supposed to go on tour with them, I can't go because I'm going to be in France. The guy is really upset. Because they didn't book the tour soon enough for me to be with

them. But I walk on tables, I walk on the bar, and still play — do whatever it took to get the band back. They got a lot of repeat business. I wish I didn't have to tell you this myself. Because it's unknown. In fact, one time I had to take a plane every day to get back to the Harlem Jazz and Blues Band, because I was double booked. I can't do it this time because I didn't have time to plan it. So the guy was going to cancel the whole tour when he found out I couldn't be there. Boozer Steinhammer. The guy that Al knew. So I took a plane every day so that they could keep the job. This time they didn't have time. I knew a month ago I couldn't make it. So they found somebody else.

MR: So when you go overseas to France or something, you go over and appear with a rhythm section that they put together for you?

JM: French musicians, yeah. That I approve. And I happen to be working all the days that they're working. If I'd known in time what was going on I could have staggered it, see I could meet them. But I'm going to say this again, and if you have time to do research I can name you the places to find it, they would not have gone back to Europe right away, or Japan, or China, if I wasn't in the band. Not because I love me, but because they saw what was going on, how I carry the band, going back to entertainment. I carry the band in such a way that you can't deny them a repeat performance. Had they just played good music and just been good guys, that wouldn't have done it. Because I knew the promoters. They were hard-nosed some of them. They wouldn't have done it. So since 2000, 2001, or 2000 to now, I've made all the tours, I literally carried the band so they can go back again. And you do that by having a multitude of experiences to project out into the audience, with the help of the band. You know what I mean? Like I incorporated the band in everything I did. But I made sure I stood out enough to give them a reason to bring us back.

MR: Were people like Lionel Hampton and Cab Calloway, were they people that you learned from?

JM: Big time, big influence. I know Cab Calloway's grandson. He runs a band. You know that don't you, Cab Calloway's. Lionel Hampton, he used to call me "Bubba." You know about that? Everyone was "Bubba." But Gladys Hampton ran the business, his wife. You know that.

MR: Yeah.

JM: Yeah. And Shotgun Kelly a man that came to be known, Shotgun Kelly was a cop in Johnstown, Pennsylvania, and he was a drummer, a show drummer. He taught me how to play drums. I do drums also by the way. I've taught many drummers how to be a show drummer. Play between my legs, behind my back, spin the sticks, just like Lionel does. I learned that from Shotgun Kelly before I met Lionel — no right after I met Lionel. And Shotgun knew how to get onstage and do a dissertation. He could speak, at random, at

any audience. This is when it was hard for blacks to do, '58, '59. Blacks are in now. Back then to be outstanding, you better be good, if you're dark-skinned. You better give the white people a reason to want to sit there and watch you. Otherwise why should they? So I can thank God for having the best training school in the world. And I never studied formally except for one semester. Yet I studied Haydn's "Trumpet Concerto," I know the "Trumpeter's Holiday," and "Flight of the Bumblebee." I took it upon myself to learn the technique. I will show you boys on stage for one minute [scats] you may not have heard that. One guy can do it all and I showed them in twenty seconds how to tu-ka tu-ka — how the back of the throat is your other tongue. You learn to use that. That's how you double tongue and triple tongue. You only have one tongue, but the other comes from the throat. Co-co-co. So I show them that in twenty seconds.

MR: When you see a chart that's got minor seven flat fives, sharp thirteens and all that, do you pay attention to that?

JM: I pay attention to what I know it means. In other words if I have a diminished chord, right, any diminished chord in any shape or form, I hear an emergency. Like movie writing, you know. I hear somebody tied up on a railroad track and the train's coming, and you're going to get destroyed if someone doesn't untie it. So I see chords in terms of idiomatic existence. Like I hear, in a major seventh, as somebody who's getting ready to leap somewhere. He ain't going yet, but he's going. Major seventh. You follow me? A minor sixth is anticipation. That's why 1-6-4-5-1 became the do-wop intro. [Scats]. And they do whole songs like that, they just change the name. So 1-6-4-5-1 became songs. Many millions of songs. Until the guy came along that wrote for the Drifters. "Under the Boardwalk" etcetera etcetera. I was in his band room before he died, in his hospital room. Remember him? What was his name? A white guy. Everybody thought he was black. A big white guy. What's his name?

MR: Not Doc —

JM: Doc Pomus. Yeah.

MR: He just passed away.

JM: I was in his hospital room every day to see him. And everybody thought he was black. See how people jump to assumption? They assumed he was black. They just assumed that, as if to say, oh somebody black got to do that. Not necessarily. He wrote all the hits.

MR: Like Jerry Lieber and Mike Stoller.

JM: There you go. I knew them too, very well. See? So there's so much you can learn about life and man and his world, like "Desiderato." I've got to mail him these. It's a piece of prose written by an airline pilot, an unknown airline pilot, became a master to read. A masterpiece. "Desiderato." You can pull it up, can't you Linda?

Linda: Oh yeah.

JM: Spell it for him please. D-I

Linda: D-E-S-I-D-E-R-A-T-O.

MR: Oh, maybe I know what you're talking about.

JM: I would give that to all my students, for them to read everyday. Just out of the blue. So you can see having been impressed with law enforcement, that's one of my greatest loves also, because of my father. Music and psychology. Psychology and philosophy, I love it, I'm married to it, that's my wife, it's my other wife. I'm married to psychology and philosophy. I made straight A's in philosophy and logic. Why I don't know. You open a philosophy book I got you. You can get any students out there who are lucky if they make a B because they don't get it. We had an open book exam at the University of Hartford. Open book exam. And the best student made a C+ or B. I made a A. So that tells me something about man and his world and nature. Why do you make an A in chemistry, biology and you can't make any in philosophy? That tells me, that answers all my questions.

MR: You are talking about — you are an imaginative man I think. And it makes me wonder when I see — you know there's a famous jazz improv method called "Anyone Can Improvise."

JM: I know about that.

MR: Do you think that's true?

JM: Well I'm improvising all the time. We improvise when I'm sitting in the chair, if I pull my coat, it's all improvisation. If I play with my fingers, you improvise all the time. Maybe not in music. But that is what you do in music. And music you fold your arms, you cross your legs, you straighten out your knees so you can relax, you think about your wife, if you've got a girlfriend you think about her too. So it's all improvisation. When you want to turn it into music it now has to gel into one musical definition. So that's when your character — you have to be able to control your character so you can push it out through the concept phrasings of the song. Like [sings] from the bottom of my heart, dear/I apologize. Billy Eckstine. This is it. "I Apologize" Billy Eckstine. So anybody can improvise if they either figure out the way or you show them the way. Because when I was growing up white musicians didn't play jazz that well. Not because they couldn't, not because they couldn't, they were in an environment that didn't condone it. They said whites can't play R&B and funk, well whites are some of the funkiest players there are today. Michael McDonald is that the guy? Who's the other guy? Oh Lord, with the raspy voice?

MR: Michael McDonald.

JM: Michael McDonald, that's another one. See?

Linda: Michael Bolton?

JM: Michael Bolton. You wouldn't get that in 1951 from — no chance. What happened? They discovered how to improvise. How to make it work. They paid attention. They paid more attention, and the blacks paid less attention, see it was like this. From 1951 to now, whites got more intuitive, blacks became less and I can prove it. I don't like the way most black musicians play today. At all. And they won't like it when I say that but I don't care either.

MR: Yeah, and you know, if you notice there seems to be more white musicians taking up jazz and blues than black musicians.

JM: Yeah. And doing it well.

MR: And why is that?

JM: Well because of the assumption theory. The up and coming blacks assume they got it. They don't have it. They assume it's a given. Well we know that. The only thing that stopped me from being an expert reader, which I am not and I don't know anybody who is, unless it's Jon Faddis. I didn't have the money to study. If I had the money to study I would have been the Wynton Marsalis of the sixties. Now I had one guy that wanted to teach me, he had a car accident and became really disabled. See it's opportunity meets faith and talent. Opportunity. Wynton had the opportunity, the faith and the talent, and he developed the work ethics. Otherwise he'd just be another guy. But it also proves that anybody can do it. [scats] Why can't you do that? Same tongue, same body. You have to be taught how to do it. So blacks failed to realize whatever works for the white man can work for him, from the late seventies on. My mother's generation understood that. They understand don't get mad get even, educationally speaking. But the blacks that grew up in the eighties, I'd say the eighties up to now, they have no clue, unless they have a have a — I say they grew up. If they were at 15 in 1980, they still have no clue. When you graduate from college, the blacks are still in the dark. I'd like to do a lecture one of these days full of a mixed audience here, and tell them exactly what's on my mind, whether they like it or not, it doesn't matter whether they like it. What matters is that they can't prove me wrong. See nobody's doing this kind of lectures anymore. So that's another reason why I'm at a loss. Nobody's telling it like it is. The guy who manages Jackson — Al Jackson — he and the late Jack the Rapper of Atlanta, Georgia. A real light-skinned DJ, they help black DJs because he was light skinned, like Adam Clayton Powell, so he'd gotten in the door. But I was begged to do some lectures and motivational speaking. I could have made a half a million dollars by now. Couldn't make up my mind when to do it. Someone asked 30 years ago to do this. Because of the way I talk, the way I project, it's both sunny and real, and it can make you listen, whether you like it or not. That's what you need.

MR: No one ever accused you of being shy.

JM: You don't get nowhere like that. Bill Gates wasn't shy either. He seems like an android but he can't be but so much an android getting to where he is. He was under the radar.

MR: Who's that?

JM: Bill Gates.

MR: Oh, right.

JM: He don't seem like an aggressive extrovert, but he's got to be inside. Otherwise he wouldn't be where he is.

MR: Do you think it's been a good, you know jazz in the last 20 years has been lifted up as an art form, now it's in all the universities, and there's a huge business of teaching jazz.

JM: It's a business. It got a lot of people jobs. It didn't get me one yet, maybe I should apply. I've been offered though, I've been offered.

MR: Do you think it's a good thing that that's happened?

JM: It's a good thing 50-50. 50 yes and 50 no. Because a lot of new people have misled, at least a quarter, a quarter out of a hundred percent, mainly the white people, have been misled by what jazz was, is and should be or will be, by the pseudo-teachers, who think they're teaching you but they're really not. The first thing you don't do, and your boy gave me credit for this too, Doc, what's his name? He gave me credit today for bringing up the church. I started, that's why I started talking first. Nobody's going to mention it. Because I'm dead serious about that. I think we need to learn where the blues and jazz as far as that genre of music, really gave birth, came from. And the reason a lot of people avoid the subject is because they don't want to talk race, they don't want to talk black. But you've got to speak racially in some sense, in order to get to the truth. I can't tell you the truth if I'm going to avoid talking about slavery. But I feel you're self-conscious, I'm self-conscious. Well how can I really tell you what you need to know if I'm busy trying to avoid that. A lot of the younger blacks, and the younger whites too, they back off what they should come on to. So the church is very important to understand. Like were you there when I told them about New Orleans?

MR: Yes.

JM: Well Charleston, South Carolina should have been the jazz center of the world. No, they decided to push slavery, cotton and rice. It's like I said today, I'll bet you a million dollars you can't find 20 black musicians who would have brought this subject up today. I don't care where they graduated from or how good they look or where they're going. They don't want to bring it up. They don't want to offend anybody. That's not your concern. If I offend you that's your problem. I'm telling the story. I hope I offend you, maybe you'll pay attention. So I'm saying so New Orleans took over because the merchants promoted jazz. They promoted it, the Creoles promoted. Charleston had to go. And I was born in Charleston, and that's my only regret. I wish I was born there. So I

spent way too long wading in the water. You know? It comes from the cotton plantation and slavery. Somehow the music culture of Charleston survived. Thank God. Because of Jenkins Orphanage. You heard about that orphanage? Daniel Jenkins Orphanage. Look up and study on Daniel Jenkins Orphanage in Charleston, South Carolina. Jabbo Smith came out of there, Cat Anderson, most of the great trumpet players, you know, have passed through the orphanage in Charleston, South Carolina.

MR: And you're going back there very soon.

JM: Tomorrow. Tomorrow, for the marathon. I'd like to live there, at the Jenkins Orphanage in Charleston, South Carolina. A lot of people you know and love either went there or passed through. And Roy Eldridge used to stop by Daniel Jenkins all the time. Lionel Hampton had a trumpet player in the band, used to always send me messages. He's way ahead of me by ten, eleven years. "Tell that boy to keep on playin'." His name was Eddie Williams, the Lionel Hampton Band. He called himself "King Ed." Because they really wanted me coming up through the ranks. Another trumpet player's name was Monk. So they heard about me and they all passed away now, it breaks my heart. And that's why when I come to see your room it represents so much more than just your room, than just your collection. It represents a whole lot more than what you have in here. John Levy and I were like this. I knew Joe Williams since 1961. Nancy Wilson, all of them. Ramsey Lewis, the girl that made "Street Life." John Levy managed her too. Jazz Crusaders he managed.

MR: Cannonball Adderley?

JM: Cannonball Adderley's brother Nat. This brings back such deep memory for me. And Joe and Nancy were his prime people.

MR: Well, and now you're a part of it, I'm going to suggest that, because I want you to have dinner —

JM: Oh I like this better.

MR: Before the concert to have some time.

JM: 8:30, what time is it?

MR: It's 6:30 now, so we can wrap this up and we'll do Part II down the road.

JM: Okay buddy. But I appreciate what you're doing. I appreciate it. I've been told also in the last twenty years at least, I've got to write a book. I've got a hell of a book to write. I can write in chapters, in segments, and verify it. Most of what I say I can verify. I mean I worked with Ray Charles and I — but see I didn't come here today really to sell me. Because I could have said all of that but I didn't. I worked with James Brown, my cousin managed James Brown — and so I could write a book at least that thick, and take it in chapters, as the martial arts world. We can talk about that for a half hour. The martial arts world, my concept of theology, my concept of criminology. I feel it's different because

usually a musician will not go down that many roads. He's too busy trying to play. So I found a way to do all of it.

MR: Fantastic. So I'm going to sign off for now, and we'll get a second opportunity.

JM: Well let me thank you very much for doing this, and God bless. But I will write that book and I've got yardage and yardage of film.